Chapter 1

Charge

If you rub a balloon against your hair, then place it next to a wall, it will stick. This is because it stole some electrons from your hair, and now the ballon has slightly more electrons than protons. We say that it has gotten an *electrical charge*, or an imbalance between protons and electrons. In this case, the balloon has a negative electrical charge. Objects with slightly more protons than electrons have a positive charge. Consequently, your hair now has a positive charge. Note that the differences are equal but opposite. While *charge* can, *net charge cannot be created or destroyed*.

An object with a negative charge and an object with a positive charge will be *attracted* to each other. Two objects with the same charge will be *repelled* by each other.

This charge, referred to as *elementary charge* is represented by the base unit e (not to be confused with the e^x function in math disciplines). This charge value e cannot be a decimal since it is a unit, just like counting coins. You cannot have a fractional amount of coins,it must be countable. In this way, we call elementary charge *quantized*. Because it is quantized, we represent the charge of a particle as q. The SI (International System of Units) measures charge in in *coulombs*. The charge of a single proton is about 1.6×10^{-19} coulombs.

Two objects with charges are bound to either attract (pull) or repel (push) on each other. This is a type of force referred to as *electric force*.

Coulomb's Law

If two objects with charge q_1 and q_2 (in coulombs) are r meters from each other, the force of attraction or repulsion (electric force) is given by

$$F = K\frac{q_1 q_2}{r^2}$$

where F is in newtons and K is Coulomb's constant: about 8.988×10^9. You may use $9 \times 10^9\,\mathrm{N \cdot m^2/C}$ in your calculations.

This k value comes from $\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0}$, a **relationship with the permittivity of free space**, ϵ_0.

You may see this as F_E or F_C, but they all refer to the electric force.

Note how similar this looks to Newton's Law of Universal Gravitation:

$$F_g = G\frac{m_p m_p}{r^2}$$

Both laws follow an inverse-square relationship, meaning the force decreases with the square of the distance. However, gravity is always attractive, while electric force can be either attractive or repulsive depending on the signs of the charges.

If this force is negative, it represents the idea that the two given particles are attracted to each other, as this would mean one of the particles must have a negative charge.

If this force is positive, it would mean there is a push or repelling force on each of the particles.

What if this force is zero? This would only result if one or both particles have zero charge. This would mean that they do not have an electric force, $F_E = 0$.

Exercise 1 Coulomb's Law

Two balloons are charged with an identical quantity and type of charge: -5×10^{-9} coulombs. They are held apart at a separation distance of 12 cm. Determine the magnitude of the electrical force of repulsion between them.

Working Space

Answer on Page 7

At this point, you might ask "If the wall has zero charge, why is the balloon attracted to it?" The answer: the electrons in the wall move away from the balloon, polarizing the atoms. The negative charge on the balloon pushes electrons away from itself, so the surface of the wall gets a mild positive charge. The negative charge on the balloon is attracted more to the positive charge on the surface of the wall than the negative charge on the inside, thus the balloon sticks. There's some weirdness going on with conductors and insulators here, but we will get to that later.

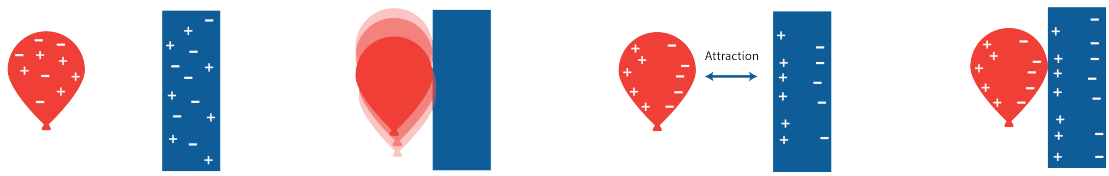
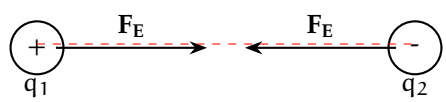


Figure 1.1: The balloon is attracted to the wall as the balloons positive charge tries to rejoin with the wall's negative charge.

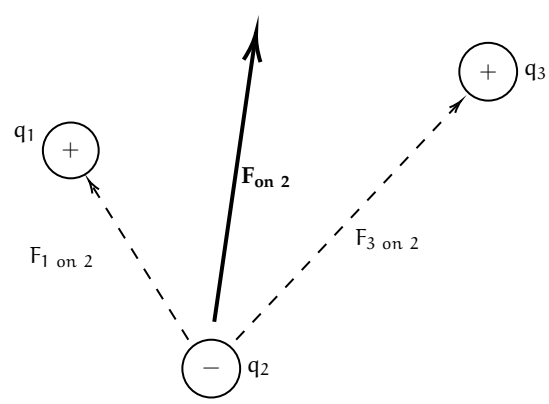
This charge acts parallel to the secant line that touches both point charges only once.



1.0.1 Superposition

What if there are more just two point charges acting on a given point charge? Coulomb's law gives the force between two point charges, but in a system with three or more charges we apply the **principle of superposition**[1].

The principle of superposition states that the total electric force on a charge is the vector sum of the individual forces exerted on it by all other charges.[2]



[1]Superposition is really a linear algebra topic, and not something that this textbook will cover, but it has so many real life applications and we recommend you do your own research! See the wiki page for more: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Superposition_principle

[2]This is similar how we calculate tensions when there are multiple tensions (or just forces in general) on an object. The net force is the sum of all the forces after vector addition is applied.

Exercise 2 Finding net charge on a point charges

Working Space

This question is taken from the AP Physics C 19th edition practice workbook.

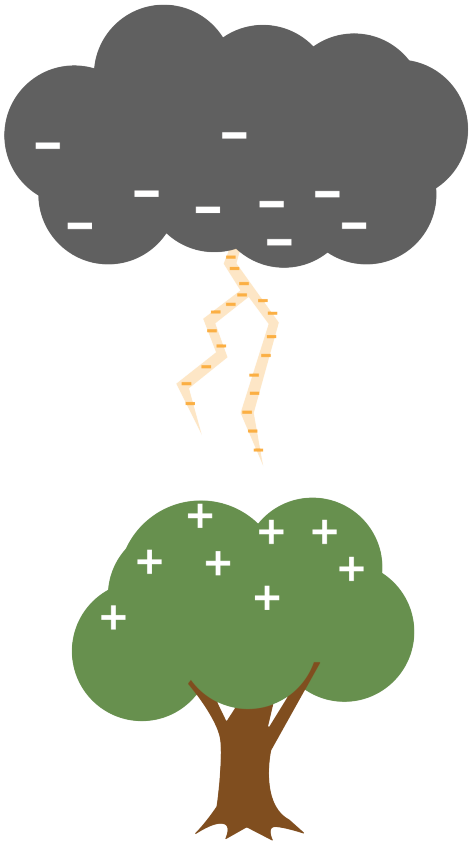
Consider four equal, positive point charges that are situated at the vertices of a square. Find the net electric force on a negative point charge placed at the square's center.

Hint: draw a diagram to help you

Answer on Page 7

1.1 Lightning

A cloud is a cluster of water droplets and ice particles. These droplets and ice particles are always moving up and down through the cloud. In this process, electrons get stripped off and end up on the water droplets at the bottom of the cloud (water droplets collect at the bottom because they are denser). The air between the droplets is a pretty good insulator, which means the electrons are reluctant to jump anywhere. However, eventually, the charge gets so strong that even the insulating properties of the air is not enough to prevent the jump, causing lightning.



A great deal of lightning moves within a cloud or between clouds. However, sometimes it jumps to the earth. These bolts of lightning vary in the amount of electrons they carry, but the average is about 15 coulombs.

Thunder occurs because the electrons heat the air they pass through, causing the air to expand suddenly. Tthe resulting shockwave is the sound we know as thunder.

1.2 But...

This idea that opposite charges attract creates some heavy questions that you do not yet have the tools to work with. So to these questions, the answer is basically "Don't ask that yet!"

However, you probably have these questions, so we will point you in the direction of the answers.

The first is "In any atom bigger than hydrogen, there are multiple protons in the nucleus. Why don't the protons push each other out of the nucleus?"

We aren't ready to talk about it, but there is a force called *the strong nuclear force*, which pulls the protons and neutrons in the nucleus of the atom toward each other. At very, very small distances, it is strong enough to overpower the repulsive force due to the protons' charges.

Another question is "Why do the electrons whiz around in a cloud so far from the nucleus of the atom? Negatively charged electrons should cling to the protons in the center, right?"

We aren't ready to talk about this either, but quantum mechanics tells us that electrons like to live in a certain specific energy level. Hugging protons isn't one of those levels.

This is a draft chapter from the Kontinua Project. Please see our website (https://kontinua.org/) for more details.

Appendix A

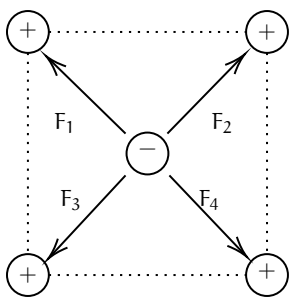
Answers to Exercises

Answer to Exercise 1 (on page 2)

$$F = K\frac{|q_1 q_2|}{r^2} = (8.988 \times 10^9)\frac{(-5 \times 10^{-9})(-5 \times 10^{-9})}{0.12^2} = \frac{224.7 \times 10^{-9}}{0.0144} = 15.6 \times 10^{-6}$$

15.6 micronewtons.

Answer to Exercise 2 (on page 4)



The attractive forces of F_1 and F_3 cancel each other out. Similarly, the attractive forces of F_2 and F_4 also cancel each other out. The net charge on the negative point charge is zero.

Index

attraction, 1

coulombs, 1
    Coulomb's law, 1

electric force, 1
electrical charge, 1
elementary charge, *see also* coulombs

principle of superposition, 3

quantized, 1

repel, 1